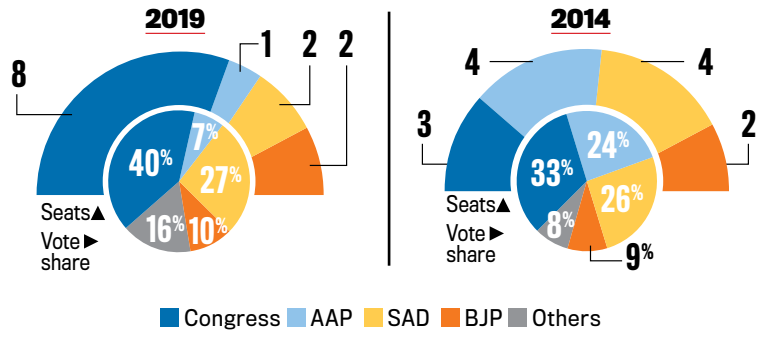
Bajwa doesn't hide his ambition to become an ideological and political alternative to Mann. He has, in this election, ensured that all his intra-party rivals—state unit chief Amarinder Singh Raja Warring, former CM Charanjit Singh Channi and former deputy CM Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa—are pushed into the electoral fray—from Ludhiana, Jalandhar and Gurdaspur, respectively. "If these candidates win, they will go to New Delhi," explains Ashutosh Kumar, who teaches political science at Panjab University, Chandigarh. "And if they lose, their political capital will be eroded forever. In both cases, Bajwa is the winner."

In another deft political manoeuvre last October, Bajwa orchestrated the return of three former ministers—Gurpreet Singh Kangar, Balbir Singh Sidhu and Raj Kumar Verka—from the BJP, effectively undermining his erstwhile comrade Jakhar. A former Punjab Congress president, Jakhar had moved to the BJP last May and was spearheading the party's outreach efforts among the rural populace, particularly the influential Jat community. Bajwa's adroit machinations not only clipped Jakhar's wings and curtailed the BJP's mission, but also solidified his own pivotal role within the Congress. Jakhar's plight is such that the central leadership didn't pay much heed to his opinion while allocating tickets, including in his home constituency Ferozepur. Here, his arch-rival Rana Gurmit Singh Sodhi—also a Congress import—is in the fray, instead of the Punjab BJP chief's choice, Raminder Singh Awla.

In the Congress, meanwhile, Bajwa is clearly calling the shots, from selecting candidates to formulating the campaign strategy. It was on his recommendation that MLA Sukhpal Singh Khaira was moved to Sangrur, away from his stronghold Kapurthala, and former Sangrur MP Vijay Inder Singla was shifted to Anandpur Sahib. When the Congress drew flak for Khaira's anti-migrant statement on the Punjabis having the first right to jobs and land in the state, Bajwa on May 22 asserted that "Khaira should take care of himself" and leave the other matters to the party. Meanwhile, those denied tickets have been pointing accusing fingers at him—former MLA Dalvir Singh Goldy, for instance, who defected to the AAP while alleging that Bajwa was orchestrating a plot against him. MLA Vikramjit Singh Chaudhary, once a close confidant who has been suspended for "anti-party activities", also blames the senior Congressman for not supporting him enough. As the campaign reached a fever pitch, all 13 Congress candidates demanded Bajwa's presence on the campaign trail, reflecting his indispensable status.

HOW PUNJAB VOTED IN THE PAST

TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS: 13



Note: The erstwhile SAD-BJP alliance had a 10-3 seat-sharing pact in both elections
Vote share figures are rounded off

The Rise of Radicals

Apart from political observers, national security experts are also keeping close tabs on developments, especially in four Lok Sabha constituencies—Sangrur, Patiala, Khadoor Sahib and Faridkot. At the heart of the contest are pro-Khalistan propagandists, with SAD (Amritsar) chief and MP Simranjit Singh Mann vying to retain his Sangrur seat, and Amritpal Singh, who is languishing in an Assam jail after his arrest under the National Security Act, throwing his hat into the ring from Khadoor Sahib.

Before he was apprehended in April last year, Amritpal had been provoking the state's youth to take up arms and prepare for a war for Khalistan while projecting himself as a modern-day Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale—the leading figure of the Sikh separatist movement killed in the 1984 Operation Blue Star. Amritpal's followers had even raided a police station in the border town of Ajnala to seek the release of one of his aides. Ironically, he now faces a former close aide of Bhindranwale, Virsa Singh Valtoha, who is the Akali Dal nominee from Khadoor Sahib—a seat with historical and religious significance for Sikhs.

In Patiala, Dharamvira Gandhi, a practising doctor and known sympathiser of the extreme left wing, is contesting on a Congress ticket. Gandhi, who won the seat in 2014 as an AAP candidate before falling out with Kejriwal, finds himself embroiled in controversy after an undated video surfaced on social media, showing him opposing sedition charges against the New York-based Khalistan proponent Sikh for Justice's Gurpatwant Singh